Social Identities: Midterm Review

An outline of the major theories and the pop quiz / review guide questions. Built from your flashcard decks (readings, lecture slides, pop quiz, and review guide). Exam: Thu Oct 22, testing center.

1. Pop quiz & review guide: the exam-style questions

Answers in the form your instructor framed them: name the concept, then say why.

Roles vs. groups (Identity Theory vs. SIT)

Give one role identity and one group identity; which theory emphasizes each?
Role (tutor, older sister): *Identity Theory*, expectations tied to a role and its counter-role. Group (Duke student, team member): *SIT*, membership and us vs. them. One identity can be both; the theories differ in emphasis.

"I'm a tutor with a tutee."
Identity Theory: a role identity gets its meaning from a counter-role and the expectations of the role.

"I'm a Blue Devil, and UNC fans are our rivals."
SIT: self-categorization into a group creates an us/them contrast and ingroup favoritism.

Two parents, one works weekends and one stays home with the kids.
Identity Theory: the parent identity differs in **salience** (and commitment); the more salient identity is invoked across more situations and guides behavior more.

How do you decide which theory applies?
By emphasis: role expectations and counter-role (Identity Theory) vs. group membership and us/them comparison (SIT).

Low-status group: status seen as legitimate and stable, and passing is possible.
Little solidarity; members try to move up alone (**individual / social mobility**).

Low-status group: status seen as unfair and changeable, boundaries impermeable.
Strong solidarity and direct competition to change the order (**social competition / social change**).

Belonging

Friendly chats with many people, but no one cares about them over time.
Missing: the stable, enduring bond of mutual care (affective concern).

One deeply caring friend, but they almost never interact.
Missing: frequent, positive interactions. The need to belong requires **both**.

Excluded from an online ball-toss game by strangers.
Cyberball: even brief exclusion by strangers lowers mood and self-esteem (social pain), so belonging is a basic need.

Gender development (Dual Pathway Model)

A: Child believes dancing is "for girls" and avoids it.
Attitudinal pathway: gender beliefs drive behavior (beliefs lead to involvement).

B: Child enjoys dancing, and the interest shapes their gender beliefs.
Personal pathway: interests (plus attention to gender) shape beliefs (interests lead to beliefs).

High gender-salience-filter girl who loves trucks?
May revise "trucks are for boys" to "for boys and girls." A low-GSF girl wouldn't link her interest to gender beliefs.

Stigma and minority stress

LGBTQ+ student worries about rejection before anything happens.
Anticipated rejection (Minority Stress Model): stigma causes stress without a new event.

Hiding an identity at a new job.
Concealment, a proximal stressor: may protect short-term, stressful over time.

"Being harassed" vs. "expecting to be harassed."
Distal (external event) vs. proximal (subjective expectation).

What protects against stigma stress?
Community connection, social support, an affirmed group identity (Bogart: disability identity protected life satisfaction).

Culture and the self (Salvador lecture)

"Interdependent cultures never self-enhance." Why too broad?
Arab and Latin American samples self-enhance like European Americans yet are interdependent. Interdependence takes different forms, and group patterns don't describe every individual.

A motive for self-enhancement besides personal uniqueness?
Ingroup protection (Arab regions): a strong, assertive self protects the group.

Sociogram: who drew themselves larger?
Larger: European Americans, Arabs, Latin Americans. Smaller: East Asians, Indians.

Intergroup contact

Two groups attend the same event but stay separate. Why isn't location enough?
Proximity doesn't create meaningful interaction. Fix: a cooperative task with a shared goal (interdependence), equal status, institutional support. Conditions facilitate, not guarantee.

Why didn't shared meals reduce hostility at Robbers Cave?
Contact alone wasn't enough; hostility eased only with superordinate goals requiring cooperation.

Other review-guide checks

Racial identity stages from scenarios
Not aware of race yet = **pre-encounter**; a comment prompts reassessment = **encounter**; exploring one's background = **immersion**; committing to an identification = **internalization & commitment**.

Biracial student told "you're not really White."
Identity denial (Albuja et al.): more stress, more reasserting the identity, slower cortisol recovery.

Family language replaced by a higher-status one / shifting speech style by audience
Subtractive bilingualism / **code-switching**.

"Others respect my groups" vs. "I'm glad to be a member"
Public vs. private **collective self-esteem**.

"I can manage this exam and learn from it."
Challenge appraisal (vs. threat): confidence, less stress, better performance.

Reflecting on your values before a hard exam
Self-affirmation theory.

Low-status group praises its warmth instead of competing on wealth
Social creativity (new comparison dimension).

2. Identity Theory (Stryker; Hogg, Terry & White, 1995)

- **Core claim:** social behavior comes from the reciprocal relationship between self and society. The self is organized into **role identities** from the roles people occupy (mother, tutor, blood donor).
- **Roots:** microsociological; symbolic interactionism (Mead, Cooley). Key names: Stryker, Burke, McCall & Simmons.

- **Counter-role:** the complementary role that gives a role meaning (mother-father, doctor-nurse, tutor-tutee). Identity theory focuses on counter-roles, *not* outgroups.
- **Identity salience:** the likelihood a role identity is invoked across situations. Identities form a **hierarchy**; higher ones guide behavior more.
- **Commitment:** how much your important relationships depend on holding the role (more commitment, more salience).
  - **Interactional** (extensivity): number of relationships tied to the role. **Affective** (intensivity): emotional importance of those ties.
- **Burke's cybernetic control:** people adjust behavior to match internal identity standards, reducing mismatch with how others see them.
- **Self-esteem:** performing a role well confirms status and raises self-esteem; poor performance brings self-doubt.
- **Stability:** identity is fairly stable (chronic salience); it changes mainly when role positions change.
- **4 central characteristics (slides):** social factors define the self; the self's social nature comes from roles; roles vary in salience; relations with others are not a main focus.

3. Social Identity Theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1979)

- **Core claim:** a social-psychological theory of intergroup relations, group processes, and the self. The categories you belong to (nationality, team, party) define who you are.
- **Origins:** Henri Tajfel's work on perception and prejudice; developed with John Turner at Bristol in the 1970s.
- **Social identity:** the parts of your self-image that come from the social categories you see yourself in.
- **Social group:** people who see themselves as one category, share emotional involvement in it, and roughly agree on its evaluation.
- **3 assumptions:** people strive for a positive self-concept; groups carry positive or negative value; a group's value comes from **social comparison** with other groups.
- **3 principles:** strive for a positive social identity; it rests on favorable ingroup-outgroup comparisons; if identity is negative, leave the group or make it more positively distinct.
- **Ingroup differentiation is strongest when** the group is internalized in the self-concept, the context allows comparison, and a relevant outgroup (similar, close, salient) is available.
- **A social identity** describes your group, prescribes how to think/feel/act, and evaluates it against other groups.
- **Two processes: self-categorization** (sharpens group boundaries via stereotypes and norms) and **self-enhancement** (the need to see your group, and so yourself, positively).
- **When a social identity is salient:** you see yourself in ingroup-stereotypical terms, see outgroup members stereotypically, and intergroup behavior can turn competitive or discriminatory.
- **Interpersonal-intergroup continuum:** from behavior set by personal relationships (old friends) to behavior set by group membership (soldiers in battle). Conflict pushes behavior toward the group end.
- **Status** is not a scarce resource; it is the outcome of intergroup comparison on valued dimensions.
- **Social competition** (driven by comparison, no real goal conflict) vs. **realistic competition** (incompatible group goals).

Belief structures and responses to a negative social identity

Belief system	What group members believe	Typical response
Social mobility	Boundaries are permeable; status is legitimate and stable; individuals can move up.	**Individual mobility**: leave or pass into the higher group. Weakens group cohesion; the group's status is unchanged.
Social change	Boundaries are impermeable (e.g., caste); status seen as illegitimate and unstable.	**Social creativity** or **social competition**: collective action, solidarity.

- **Social creativity** (redefine the comparison, status unchanged): new dimension (Lemaine's hut-building kids), change the value ("Black is beautiful"), change the comparison group (Rosenberg & Simmons: Black people comparing with other Black people had higher self-esteem).

- **Social competition:** directly challenge the higher-status group to change status relations.

Self-Categorization Theory (J. C. Turner): SIT's cognitive side

- **Accentuation:** categorizing exaggerates similarity within and difference between categories.
- **Depersonalization:** seeing yourself as an embodiment of the group prototype (not dehumanization).
- **Prototype:** fuzzy mental picture of a group's defining attributes. **Metacontrast:** prototypes minimize within-group and maximize between-group differences, so they shift with the salient outgroup (identity is **dynamic**).
- **Salience** comes from fit with the context plus motivated availability.

4. Identity Theory vs. SIT at a glance

	Identity Theory	Social Identity Theory
Discipline	Sociological (microsociology, symbolic interactionism)	Social psychological (sociocognitive processes)
Self organized by	Roles (role identities)	Group memberships (group norms)
Meaning comes from	Counter-roles	Outgroups (us vs. them comparison)
Intergroup relations	Not a focus	Central
Stability	Fairly stable, chronic salience	Dynamic, context-dependent
Cognitive processes	Little emphasis	Detailed: categorization, depersonalization
Best at	Chronic identities, interpersonal interaction	Intergroup behavior, identity dynamics
Class examples	Older sister (vs. younger sibling); tutor-tutee	Duke student vs. UNC; team member

- **Similarities:** both see the self as socially constructed and multiple, organize behavior into meaningful units, and explain how identities are internalized.
- **Hogg et al.'s "Tale of Two Theories":** remarkably similar but in "parallel but separate universes" with almost no cross-referencing. 4 differences: level of analysis; role of intergroup behavior; relation between roles and groups; salience of social context.
- **Roles inside SIT:** positions within a group that give individual distinctiveness, not a social identity.

5. Intergroup conflict and contact

- **Categorization is fast:** within 100-200 ms (age, gender, race, expression, group symbols). **Ingroup bias:** favoring your own group.
- **Realistic Group Conflict Theory (Sherif; term from Campbell, 1965):** competition over scarce resources causes prejudice. Competition raises ingroup morale and cohesion. **Superordinate goals** reduce conflict.
  - **Problems (Tajfel & Turner):** bias appears with no conflict of interest (minimal groups), and low-status groups sometimes favor the dominant group.
- **Robbers Cave (Sherif):** 22 White boys, 11-12. Phases: acquaintance, group formation (Eagles vs. Rattlers), competition, cooperation. Competition caused hostility; pleasant contact (shared meals) didn't fix it; superordinate goals did.
- **Minimal group paradigm (Tajfel, 1970/71):** trivial categories, anonymous allocations, no interaction or self-interest, yet ingroup favoritism. People chose **maximum difference** over maximum ingroup profit. Billig & Tajfel (1973): even explicitly random groups showed bias.
- **Turner's Arts vs. Science:** more bias when the dimension mattered and the outgroup was similar, especially with stable status.
- **Allport's contact conditions:** equal status, common goals, cooperation, support from authorities/law/custom. **Pettigrew & Tropp (2006)**, 515 studies: contact generally reduces prejudice; conditions facilitate, aren't required.
- **Mousa's soccer study** (post-ISIS Iraq): mixed Christian-Muslim teams built lasting peer ties, but didn't erase prejudice toward strangers.
- **Blue eyes / brown eyes** (Jane Elliott, 1968): arbitrary categories quickly produce favoritism and bias.

6. The other major theories, by unit

Belonging: Baumeister & Leary (1995)

- **Need to belong:** a pervasive drive for a minimum number of lasting, positive, significant relationships.
- **Two parts:** frequent, pleasant interactions *and* a stable bond of mutual concern.
- Evidence: bonds form easily (Robbers Cave, minimal groups) and resist dissolution. **Satiation:** a few close bonds matter most. **Substitution:** a new bond helps replace a lost one. Rejection brings anxiety, depression, loneliness; ostracism causes social pain.
- Belonging is claimed to be **nonderivative** (a basic motive), the least supported part. Maslow put it mid-hierarchy.

Self-esteem: collective self-esteem and self-affirmation

- **Crocker & Luhtanen (1990):** collective self-esteem (CSE) is an individual difference in how positive your social identity is. High-CSE people indirectly enhanced the ingroup (rating others in ways that favored their group); low-CSE people didn't change their ratings. The effect didn't appear with personal self-esteem.
- CSE subscales include **private** (I'm glad to be a member) and **public** (others respect my groups).
- **Stress appraisal (Lazarus & Folkman):** relevant? harmful or beneficial? can I cope? **Challenge** vs. **threat** appraisal.
- **Self-affirmation theory:** reflecting on your values protects self-esteem under stress.

Culture and the self: Salvador lecture; Kitayama & Salvador (2024)

- **Independent vs. interdependent self** (Markus & Kitayama, 1991).
- **Varieties of interdependence:** conflict avoidance (East Asia), ingroup protection (Arab regions), emotional expression (Latin America), argumentation (South Asia).
- **Key lesson:** the same tendency (self-enhancement) can serve independence in one culture and interdependence in another (**schematic principle**).
- Dimensions: independent/interdependent; individualism/collectivism; tight/loose norms; relational mobility. **Rice vs. wheat** (Talhelm): rice regions are more interdependent.
- **Brewer & Yuki:** SIT may apply most to Western intergroup situations.

Racial and ethnic identity: Rogers et al. (2012), Rhodes (2013)

- **Racial vs. ethnic identity:** appearance-based classification vs. shared nationality, culture, history, language.
- **Stages:** pre-encounter, encounter, immersion, internalization & commitment.
- **Rogers:** middle childhood is active meaning-making; few age differences, lots of variability across groups (uses SIT).
- **Rhodes:** two intuitive theories, categories as **natural kinds** vs. as **markers of social obligation**. Children recognize race early but essentialize it later, and it varies by culture. Generic language ("boys like trucks") encourages essentialism; diversity makes beliefs more flexible.

Multiracial identity: Gaither (2015), Wilkins et al. (2010), Yampolsky et al. (2021)

- **Why SIT doesn't fully fit:** multiracials have more than one ingroup, may not identify as multiracial, and identification can fluctuate.
- **Identity denial** (Albuja et al.): stress, reassertion, slower cortisol recovery. **Townsend (2009):** forced one-race choice lowers self-esteem. **Cheng & Lee (2009):** multiracial identity helps only when identities feel overlapping. **Identity flexibility:** switching between identities.
- **Phenotypic prototypicality (Wilkins):** looking prototypical links to more discrimination and more identification; perceivers infer identification from appearance.
- **Identity integration (CDSMII, Amiot et al.):** integration, compartmentalization, categorization.

Language: Hansen & Liu (1997), DeJesus, Werker & Byers-Heinlein (2008)

- Language marks group membership, as SIT predicts. **Ethnolinguistic identity theory** (Giles & Johnson): groups compare to gain positive distinctiveness; the **negative comparison** strategy (assimilating) can erode the original language (**subtractive bilingualism**).

- **Code-switching** signals identity. **DeJesus:** accent stereotypes form in childhood (5-6: ingroup preference only for northern accents; 9-10: shared stereotypes).
- **Bilingualism myths:** it doesn't confuse children; infants separate their languages and the mind is ready for two first languages.

Gender: gender schema theory, Coyle & Liben (2016), Olson et al. (2015), Edwards & Jones (2009), Latu et al. (2013)

- **Gender schema theory** (Martin & Halverson): children attend to what's self-relevant based on what's "for girls/boys." **Constructivist:** children actively process gender.
- **Dual Pathway Model:** attitudinal (beliefs lead to behavior) vs. personal (interests lead to beliefs). **Coyle & Liben:** after Barbie, high-GSF girls grew more interested in feminine jobs; low-GSF girls didn't change.
- **Olson et al.:** transgender children look like cisgender children of the same gender identity; they are not confused.
- **Edwards & Jones:** college men "put on a man face" (a mask): learn expectations, put on the mask, wear it, begin taking it off. A process, not stages.
- **Latu et al.:** subtle reminders of successful women improved women's behavior and closed the gender gap.

Disability and stigma: Bogart (2014), Minority Stress Model (Meyer, 2003)

- **Minority model / social model:** disability's negatives are largely social (stigma, no accommodations); Stella Young: society disables people more than bodies do.
- **Managing stigma (SIT):** assimilate/pass vs. affirm and develop pride.
- **Bogart:** congenital onset linked to higher life satisfaction, partly via disability identity and self-efficacy (not self-esteem).
- **Minority stress:** stigma adds chronic stress. **Distal** (discrimination) vs. **proximal** (expected rejection, vigilance, concealment, internalized stigma). Buffers: community, support, positive group identity.